

thin crowds. Yet, nothing disappointed quite like the Sri Lanka Cricket Museum housed within the board's headquarters. The exhibits trace the nation's cricketing journey but abruptly stop at 2016. The small room is lined with trophies from continental and bilateral triumphs, including a proud display of the 2014 Men's T20 World Cup silverware. But the cherished Women's Asia Cup trophy, won in Dambulla in 2024 after beating India, remains tucked away somewhere in a box; one among many updates the museum sorely needs. It is an opportunity lost for a nation hosting the women's world showpiece for the first time.

Lavanya Lakshmi Narayanan

A city tuned to a different frequency

When the Diary stepped into the taxi pick-up area of the Lokpriya Gopinath Bordoloi International Airport, it was pleasantly surprised to spot a few billboards promoting the Women's World Cup. But as soon as the cab began its 20-odd kilometre journey into Guwahati city, the Diary was greeted by countless signages paying tribute to Zubeen Garg, the iconic Assamese singer who had recently passed away, outside homes and traffic signals alike.

"He's considered a legend here. People loved him because he wasn't afraid to speak his mind, even if it meant going against the establishment," said a media member from the Assam Cricket Association.

It was only natural then that the opening match of the tournament between India and Sri Lanka, held in the city, drew record-breaking crowds for a special Garg tribute. His loyal followers made sure they didn't miss it.

Garg's voice is unmistakable and seems to follow you wherever you go in Guwahati. You could be in your hotel room writing about how Bangladesh nearly beat England and swear you heard someone outside humming Ya Ali. His voice lingers in restaurants, filling the air, and even at the Barsapara Stadium, helping a groundsman get through his day.

While the New Zealand team trained in the nets to songs like Here Without You by 3 Doors Down, it was clear to the Diary that cricket may come and go in Guwahati, but Zubeen Garg will live forever.

Rajdeep Saha

The fan who finally asked

Landing in Colombo ahead of the final few league matches of the Women's ODI World Cup, the Diary had expected to see signs of support for Sri Lanka, which still had three home games remaining.

Every local who asked the reason for visiting received the same reply: cricket coverage at the R. Premadasa, fondly known as Khetarama. For days, tuk-tuk drivers ferried the Diary to and from the stadium, passing the usual flags and banners, yet none seemed curious enough to ask who was playing.

Until one afternoon, a wide-eyed Nallasamy hesitated before accepting his fare and asked if spectators were allowed to watch. When told that entry was free, his face lit up even more. On learning that Sri Lanka was playing "a good team", South Africa, he promised to park nearby and join in.

Later, when the cameras panned across the nearly empty stands, the Diary smiled. There he was, cheering the teams on despite the rain.

Kavita Menon



Urban rhythm: Brightly painted tuk-tuks wait outside Colombo's R Premadasa Stadium, as much a symbol of the city's pulse as the cricket they ferry fans to. KAVITA MENON



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